VON ZAROVICH ESTATE / STATION 1

# The Library

*Empty hands. Watchful eyes.*

The door sighs shut behind you, stirring a cloud of dust that glitters in the candlelight. Tall bookshelves crowd the walls, their shelves bowed beneath cracked leather volumes. Somewhere among them, a page turns. Neither of you touched a book.

Six stone ancestors stand in shadowed alcoves, their empty hands extended as if expecting gifts. Small nameplates identify Victoria, Alexi, Teresa, Valerius, Borislav, and Barov. Their faces are stern enough to make whispering feel compulsory. Barov stands higher than the others, on a tall plinth.

A rumpled velvet runner covers part of a heavy reading table. Six carved relics rest upon it: a book, a scythe, a dagger, a spear, a hammer, and a crown. Candle flames tremble across their edges. Behind the statues, the Archive Gate remains firmly closed.

Above the fireplace crouches a stone gargoyle. You could swear its eyes follow your hands. A log cracks in the hearth, loud as a snapped bone. For a moment, every statue seems to be waiting for you to make the first move.

What do you do? Talk with your partner. Tell the DM what you want to examine or try. Your character sheet may give you ideas.